GÖBEKLİTEPE

A Journey to the Past with Gogo the Fox

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uçan fil

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My name is Gogo. I am a red fox. We red foxes belong to the canine family, which means dogs, wolves, and jackals are our closest cousins. Our scientific name is Vulpes vulpes.

Like you humans, we are highly adaptable creatures. Whether it is hot or cold, wet or dry, we can live in almost every part of the world. We are omnivores too, just like you, which means we eat both plants and meat. It turns out we have quite a lot in common, don't we?

I've heard that humans often describe foxes as "sly." I suppose that comes from the old story about the crow and the fox. It's true that we are smarter than many other animals, but I must admit, I feel a little offended when you call us cunning. Just so you know!



I live where Göbeklitepe stands today. This is a very important place in human history. Long ago, people here built remarkable structures, statues, and stone carvings. Sadly, over time they abandoned this place. The things they created were slowly buried under layers of soil until the site turned into a hill. That is why it was named Göbeklitepe, which means "Potbelly Hill." For many years, no one knew that people had once lived here, until archaeologists discovered the site and uncovered it once again.

How do I know all this? Well, the archaeologists working at Göbeklitepe are my best friends. Sometimes I sit and watch them work all day long. They share not only their food with me, but also their knowledge. Everything I know about Göbeklitepe, I learned from them.

But I am going to share a secret with you, one the archaeologists do not know: We foxes discovered Göbeklitepe long before humans did.



The Explorers of Göbeklitepe

We foxes usually build our dens underground. Long ago, before Göbeklitepe had been discovered, my great-great-grandmother and great-great-grandfather were digging a new home for themselves. My great-great-grandmother was expecting babies, and they needed a safe shelter before winter arrived. As they dug deeper into the ground together, they suddenly hit a stone. Strange shapes were carved onto its surface. They tried digging around it to move it out of the way, but it was no use. The stone was so enormous that they eventually gave up.

Curious and excited, they told the other foxes what had happened. Soon, foxes lined up outside the hole just to catch a glimpse of the giant stone. None of them had ever seen anything like it before. Back then, humans did not know about these ancient stone structures either. Ever since then, foxes living around here have told this story with great excitement, as if it happened only yesterday. Discovering Göbeklitepe before humans is still a matter of pride for us foxes.



Göbeklitepe was discovered in 1963 during a joint survey carried out by archaeologists from Istanbul University and the University of Chicago. The archaeologist who later began the excavations at Göbeklitepe and introduced the site to the world was a German researcher named Klaus Schmidt.



Klaus Schmidt had previously worked at a site called Nevali Çori, which was similar to Göbeklitepe. Today, Nevali Çori lies beneath the waters of the Atatürk Dam Lake. The moment Schmidt saw Göbeklitepe in 1993, he realized it was an extraordinary place. He quickly formed a team of archaeologists and began research and excavations at the site. Sadly, I never had the chance to meet him myself, because he passed away in 2014. But the work he started at Göbeklitepe is still being continued by his colleagues today.

Where is Göbeklitepe Located?

Göbeklitepe is located in southeastern Türkiye, at the summit of the Germuş Mountains, about fifteen kilometres east of the city center of Şanlıurfa.

As I mentioned before, I live on that mountain too. The view here is absolutely magnificent. When I stand at the top and look into the distance, I can see the peaks of Mount Nemrut and the Southeastern Taurus Mountains to the north, and Karacadağ to the east. To the south stretches the vast Harran Plain as far as the eye can see. Perhaps the people who built Göbeklitepe thousands of years ago chose this place for its extraordinary location and breathtaking view as well.



Fertile Crescent

Did you notice the green area on the map? The region that includes Göbeklitepe, and the mountain where I live is called the Fertile Crescent by archaeologists. The reason for this name is that the region is extremely rich in natural resources, or in other words, very fertile.

Wild varieties of many plants and nuts, such as wheat, barley, lentils, pistachios, and almonds, grew naturally here without any human help. People did not need to plant or farm them at all.

The Fertile Crescent was also home to the wild ancestors of animals like sheep, goats, and pigs, as well as deer and gazelles. Thanks to its abundant water sources, including seas, lakes, and rivers, fish and shellfish were plentiful too.

So, don't you think this region truly deserves to be called "fertile"? For your hunter-gatherer and nomadic ancestors, this place must have felt like paradise. You do not know what "hunter-gatherer" or "nomadic" means? Then you should turn the page and find out!



Hunter-Gatherer and the Nomadic Life

Today, most people live in apartment buildings or houses. They buy their food, clothes, and other necessities from places such as markets, shops, and shopping malls. But life was not nearly this easy for your ancestors long ago. To protect themselves from cold weather and wild animals, they sheltered in caves or in simple tents made from wood, animal bones, and animal skins. They had to gather wild plants growing in nature and hunt animals in order to find food. They also made their own clothing from animal hides and plant fibers.

Under these conditions, people lived in small groups so they could support and help one another. They moved from place to place frequently in search of new food sources. This way of life is known as hunter-gatherer and nomadic life.

The Old Stone Age / Palaeolithic Age

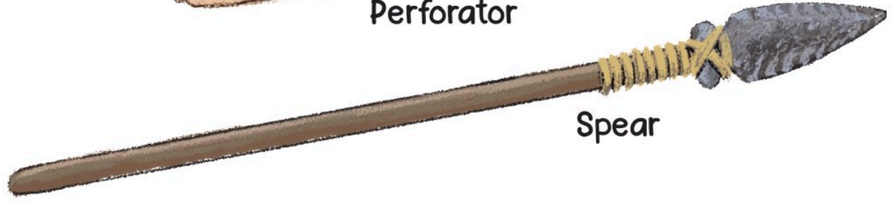
Archaeologists call the period when hunter-gatherers and nomadic people lived the Old Stone Age, or the Paleolithic Age (paleo = old, lithic = stone). That is because people during this time mostly used stone to make tools. Besides stone tools, they also made tools from wood, reeds, animal bones, and antlers. However, only a few of these have survived to the present day.



Hand axe



Perforator



Spear

The Old Stone Age began about 2.5 million years ago and ended around 15,000 years ago. I can almost hear you asking, "What happened 15,000 years ago that brought the Old Stone Age and the hunter-gatherer way of life to an end?" During the Old Stone Age, Earth's climate was much colder and drier than it is today. About 15,000 years ago, the climate began to change, and before long, conditions similar to today's climate spread across the world. As the climate changed, major changes also began to appear in the lives of the hunter-gatherer and nomadic people living in the Fertile Crescent.